This is truly India's moment in history. Mega opportunities are today emerging from the diversification in global supply chains, the all-pervasive digital revolution, and the urgent need for a green transition. The synergy of India's large market, favourable demographics, rising disposable incomes, technological prowess and vibrant entrepreneurship will continue to power growth in the foreseeable future. While purposeful policies can accelerate the pursuit of these unbounded opportunities, we deeply believe that enterprises rooted in India, as economic organs of society, can play a vital role in partnering the nation in the promising journey ahead.

Role of Indian Enterprise

To my mind, exemplary enterprises contribute to nation building by not only making uncompromising efforts to be globally competitive but also by embedding larger societal value creation at the core of corporate strategy. Stakeholder value through 'purposeful performance' is indeed the bedrock on which progressive enterprises will be built in the future.

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A nation's competitiveness gets enhanced when world-class national brands are assiduously built to retain larger value in the country whilst serving domestic and global markets. Further, investments in state-of-the-art assets, cutting-edge R&D and social infrastructure build competitive capacity for nations. Business models that integrate the creation of environmental capital and large-scale sustainable livelihoods enrich a nation's resources & the social fabric, contributing to a more secure and resilient future. Focussed action to shape brands with purpose, promote diversity & inclusion and build capabilities of local communities strengthen society in more ways than one.

Accelerating Livelihood Generation

It is universally acknowledged that India's favourable demographics constitutes one of its greatest strengths. More than a billion people, comprising nearly 70% of the population, will be of working age by 2030.

Over the next decade, almost a quarter of the incremental global workforce will be from India. This powerhouse of productive human capital is unquestionably a source of unique competitive advantage as well as a formidable driver of consumption.

The journey of economic transformation with purposeful interventions has set in place a virtuous cycle of investment and employment creating quality jobs.

The impressive growth of Global Capability Centres re-affirms India's rising stature as a workplace for the world. The Budget 2024 has also announced multidimensional programmes to boost skilling and employment, strengthen MSMEs as well as provide impetus to labour-intensive sectors. The ONDC platform set up recently can also lend new wings to micro and small enterprises akin to the UPI's remarkable impact on financial transactions.

ITC: Supporting Livelihoods

ITC's deep engagements in agriculture, manufacturing and services, including hospitality and tourism, support millions of livelihoods across several value chains. It is well acknowledged that the tourism potential is boundless and plays a pivotal role in anchoring large-scale livelihood generation.

More so, given the variety of unrivalled destinations the country possesses across nature, wild-life, adventure, heritage, medical or pilgrimage tourism as well as MICE and wedding focussed opportunities. The Government has rightly taken proactive steps to promote this sector.

According to the draft Tourism Policy, employment can grow from 88 million currently to 400 million by 2047, with tourism GDP growing from US$ 143 billion to US$ 1 trillion, highlighting the exponential growth potential. The emerging trends of micro-tourism, immersive experiences and multiple short vacations will also add new dimensions to this industry.

The tourism sector's resurgence points to the immense potential of this industry to generate gainful employment.

Supply of rooms in India currently stands at only 0.11 per 1,000 population relative to the world average of about 2.2, highlighting the enormous headroom for growth. World-class convention facilities, such as the Bharat Mandapam and the Yashobhoomi Centre, have hosted prestigious global events and showcase India's competitive edge in prestigious MICE events. While global campaigns to promote India's treasure-house of tourism assets remain imperative, concerted efforts are also required to scale up skilling to meet emerging demand.

Your Company has made significant investments in building skilled hospitality talent through 6 focussed programmes, including the ITC Hospitality Management Institute and the Welcomgroup Graduate School of Hotel Administration.

Enriching India's tourism landscape, your Company's Hotels Business, with its repertoire of iconic properties, globally acknowledged cuisines, service excellence and ethos of Responsible Luxury is well poised to leverage the emerging opportunities.

The asset-right strategy, envisioned for the next horizon of growth, together with the impending move to give new wings to ITC Hotels as a pure-play entity foretells an exciting future. 32 hotels have been opened in the last 24 months, taking the total to nearly 140 hotels. **The robust pipeline of managed properties will take the overall footprint to over 200 hotels in the coming years, enabling ITC to enlarge its contribution to employment generation.**